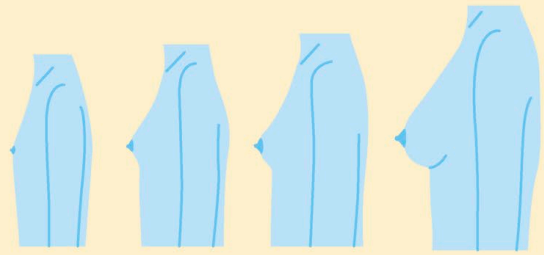


Breast development

The breast bud—a small, firm bump that appears under the nipple and surrounding areola—is one of the first signs of puberty. It usually appears between the ages of 9 and 10 due to an increase in the body's level of estrogen, one of the female sex hormones. At first, breast buds might feel tender, or sore, but this should pass.

Over time, as glandular tissue and fatty tissue develop, the breasts grow bigger and rounder. The areola darkens and becomes enlarged. The nipples may start to protrude outward from the breast.



△ Stages of growth

Breast development is triggered by the female sex hormone estrogen.

Common concerns

Teens may sometimes worry about their breasts and how they look. Here are the most common concerns:

Developing early or late

Everyone develops at different times. How fast breasts grow is not related to what they will eventually look like.

Asymmetrical breasts

Most of the time breasts will gradually become more even, but natural breasts are not completely symmetrical.

Tenderness

Some teens experience breast tenderness in the days leading up to a period, but this should end with the period.

Inverted nipples

Some teens find their nipples go into the breast. They may pop out eventually, but some never do. This is nothing to worry about.

Hairy nipples

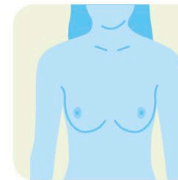
Hair around the nipples is completely normal. Plucking the hair is fine if a person doesn't like the way it looks.

Stretch marks

Breast tissue may grow faster than the skin on the surface. This can cause fine lines, called stretch marks, to appear, but they will fade over time.

Self-checks

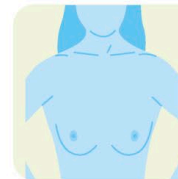
Girls and women should check their breasts regularly and get to know how they feel at different times in their menstrual cycle. This will allow them to notice any changes sooner. If there are any changes, or if there is pain or discharge, it's best to see a doctor as quickly as possible.



1. Stand in front of a mirror and look at both breasts for any changes in shape, size, or asymmetry.



2. Clasp hands behind the head and press hands forward to tense the muscles. Check for changes in the skin or nipple, and for discharge.



3. Press hands firmly on hips and bow slightly forward. Look for any visible changes.



4. Lie down with one arm above the head. Press small circles all around the flesh of each breast, including the nipple and armpit. Feel for any changes in the breast tissue.